HongSeok Kim

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Education

Iowa State University — Ames, IA
Ph.D. in Economics — 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation Committee: Juan Carlos Córdoba (Chair), Rajesh Singh, Quinn Weninger, Sergio Lence, and Jian Li

Hanyang University — Seoul, Republic of Korea
M.A. in Economics and Finance — 2021
B.A. in Economics and Finance — 2019

Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Public Economics, Economics of Aging

Job Market Paper

Optimal Social Security Reform with a Debt Ceiling and Learning by Doing [Link]

Abstract. Once the Social Security trust fund is depleted, all bets are off. The most likely scenario is what I call the baseline or no-reform case: an initial transition of increasing government transfers to finance the Social Security deficit, which would increase national debt up to a ceiling, followed by a combination of higher payroll taxes and lower benefits. Can a different adjustment path mitigate this burden without making any generation worse off on average than under the no-reform? I study this transition in a general-equilibrium overlapping-generations model calibrated to the United States in 2010, with learning by doing and a public-debt ceiling of 150% of GDP. The baseline economy finances scheduled benefits through borrowing until the debt ceiling binds and benefit reductions follow. I construct a reform that lowers the payroll tax to 3.5% by 2200 and reduces benefits more relative to baseline, without average welfare losses for any birth cohort. Cohort-specific payroll-tax relief during working life and benefit supplements for low-income individuals late in retirement protect transition cohorts. A consumption tax finances both under the same debt ceiling, at a present-value cost of 2.2% of 2026 GDP. Learning by doing is essential to this result: without it, the gains from lower payroll taxation are insufficient to finance the cohort-specific payroll tax relief and benefit supplements. Complete phase-out produces larger long-run output gains but imposes welfare losses on many cohorts alive today. Retaining a smaller program, as implied by my reform, yields higher social welfare than phase-out when the government counts only cohorts alive today or weights lightly future cohorts through dynastic altruism.

Working Papers

The Intergenerational Welfare Cost of Social Security Insolvency [Link]

Abstract. This paper asks which generations bear the welfare cost of Social Security insolvency. The trust fund is expected to be depleted in 2033, but each generation meets it at a different age, with different years of benefits at stake and different means of adjusting. In a life-cycle model with endogenous saving, labor supply, human capital, and claiming, I quantify how the expected duration of reduced payments shifts that welfare incidence. The main result is that the cohort losing the most unpaid dollars is not the cohort losing the most welfare. Households that expect the shortfall self-insure by saving, working, and human-capital investment, but the cost of doing so depends on age. The youngest cohorts spread the adjustment over a career, whereas mid-career

cohorts must compress it into the years before retirement and end up worse off than if the shortfall had been a surprise. Duration matters as well. When the shortfall is brief, the burden lands mainly on retirees, and when it is prolonged, the burden shifts to the working generations behind them.

Fertility Inertia under Ambiguity Aversion [Link]

Abstract. High family-policy spending often produces only small changes in fertility. I study this problem in a Barro–Becker model. Parents value descendants' utility, dislike risk in its total value, and assess family plans by their worst-case value. They are uncertain about how well public news predicts children's outcomes. Information inertia creates an interval of bad news in which welfare falls but locally optimal fertility, investment per child, and consumption remain unchanged. Reliable subsidies can still raise fertility. An explicit policy solution discounts uncertain benefits by the lowest possible delivery rate. Thus, unclear delivery requires larger promises for the same fertility response. More effective support raises fertility and shifts and widens the inertia interval. Less uncertainty about signal informativeness narrows it for a fixed family plan. This suggests two policy dimensions: generosity and legibility. The exact inertia result is limited to maxmin preferences, continuous fertility, and a local normal representation.

Work in Progress

Optimal Immigration Policy under Private Information: A Macroeconomic Approach

Insurance and Learning about Self-Protection: Evidence from Conservation Reserve Program
(with Hyewon Lee)

Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

Graduate Teaching Excellence Award (Top 10%), Iowa State University	2026
Professional Advancement Grant (PAG), Iowa State University	2026
Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International	2026
Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University	2025
Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Research Travel Grant ($750) × 6, Iowa State University	2023 – 2026
Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020 – 2021
HY-IN Graduate School Academic Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020
Korea Student Aid Foundation Academic Fellowship	2019
Graduation Award, Hanyang University	2019

Teaching Experience

Sole Instructor

ECON 1020	Principles of Macroeconomics	Undergrad	Summer 2025	4.36

Recitation Instructor – Graduate

ECON 6040	Advanced Macroeconomic Analysis	Ph.D. core	Spring 2024, 2025, 2026	5.00
ECON 6020	Macroeconomic Analysis	Ph.D. core	Fall 2025	5.00
ECON 6030	Advanced Microeconomics – Game Theory	Ph.D. core	Spring 2023	4.67
ECON 5710	Intermediate Econometrics	Master's	Spring 2026	4.50

ECON 5000	Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I	Master's	Fall 2026	

Teaching Assistant / Lab Instructor – Undergraduate

ECON 3020	Intermediate Macroeconomics	Undergrad	2025	5.00
ECON 3710	Introduction to Econometrics	Undergrad	2021	4.29
ECON 1020	Principles of Macroeconomics	Undergrad	2022–2025	
ECON 1010	Principles of Microeconomics	Undergrad	2021, 2023, 2024	

Presentations, Conferences, and Workshops

([†]Scheduled)

2026: 96th Southern Economic Association (Houston)[†], Midwest Macro Fall Meetings (Texas Tech)[†], 21st Economics Graduate Student Conference (Washington University in St. Louis), Econometric Society Conference on Dynamic Structural Econometrics (University of Michigan), 101st Western Economic Association International, North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society (Emory University), Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society (Vietnam; accepted, cancelled)

2025: Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists (Iowa State University)

2024: Southern Economic Association (Washington, D.C.), 19th Economics Graduate Student Conference (Washington University in St. Louis), Midwest Macro Fall Meetings (Purdue University), Macro Reading Group (Iowa State University)

2023: Midwest Economic Association (Chicago)

Academic Service

Discussant, "Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada," MEA, Chicago	2024
Guest Lecture, ECON 3270: Quantity–Quality Trade-off in Becker's Model	2025
Economics Help Room Services for Undergraduates, Iowa State University	2021, 2023

Skills and Additional Information

Software: Fortran (OpenMP/MPI), Python, Julia, Stata

Citizenship: Republic of Korea (F-1 visa)

Military Service: Republic of Korea, mandatory service (on leave from Hanyang University), 2012 – 2014

References

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